

COLORADO OWNER-BUILDER PERMIT KIT

Two permit systems · One house · Find out which offices own yours

Project Address: _____

County: _____

City / unincorporated: _____

Owner-Builder: _____

Every Colorado statute, board rule, and requirement in this kit is cited on
the page it appears on — verified August 2026.

BUILD YOUR HOUSE

build-your-house.com

First Edition — 2026

How to Use This Kit

Five working documents that take a Colorado owner-builder from "which office does my house even answer to?" to a house you can legally occupy, insure, and — the part Colorado enforces hardest — get permanent power to.

Most states hand you one permit counter. Colorado hands you two, and they are decided separately. **The building permit is entirely local.** Colorado adopts no statewide residential building code and licenses no general contractor; a board of county commissioners is merely "*authorized to*" adopt a building code, and the duty to get a permit exists only "*after the adoption of the building code*" — so in some unincorporated counties there is no building permit to apply for at all. **The electrical and plumbing permits are STATE permits.** Unless your city or county runs its own qualifying inspection program, you buy those permits from the Colorado State Electrical Board and the State Plumbing Board and a state inspector comes out.

The Colorado inversion — read this twice

It is entirely possible, and common, to build in unincorporated Colorado where **no building permit exists for your house** and a **state permit is still required before you run the first wire or the first pipe**. People who hear "my county has no building code" and conclude "no permits" are wrong in the most expensive way available: the utility may not connect permanent power without proof of final electrical approval. (C.R.S. 30-28-205(1); 12-115-120(2)(a), (1)(c))

TWO SYSTEMS, ONE HOUSE — THE HEADLINE OF THIS KIT

The local track and the state track are settled separately

	LOCAL — the building permit	STATE — electrical, plumbing, gas piping
Who decides whether it exists	Your county or municipality, alone. A board of county commissioners " <i>is authorized to</i> " adopt a building code (30-28-201(1)); until it does, there is no county building permit (30-28-205(1)). Home-rule cities set their own.	The General Assembly, statewide. The permit exists for every installation in new construction — the only question is who issues it .
Who issues it	The county building department or the city. If your jurisdiction adopted no code, nobody does — and no building permit is required.	The State Electrical Board and the State Plumbing Board — unless your local government runs its own qualifying program, in which case the local building department does (12-115-120(1)(a)(I); 12-155-120(1)(a)).

The local track and the state track are settled separately

	LOCAL — the building permit	STATE — electrical, plumbing, gas piping
Which code applies	Whichever edition your jurisdiction adopted, with local amendments — this kit prints no edition, because there is no statewide answer. Ask, and write it down.	The National Electrical Code and the Colorado plumbing code as adopted by the boards — a statewide floor . Local governments may be stricter, never weaker (12-115-107(2)(a)(I); 12-155-106(2)).
May you pull it yourself	Local policy. Most Colorado jurisdictions let an owner permit their own home; some attach an affidavit or occupancy condition. Confirm in writing — CO.1.	Yes, by statute. " <i>Qualified applicant</i> " expressly includes " <i>a homeowner performing work on the homeowner's home</i> " for both permits (12-115-120(11)(c); 12-155-120(11)(c)).

C.R.S. 30-28-201(1), 30-28-205(1), 31-15-601; 12-115-120(1)(a)(I), (2)(a), (11)(c); 12-155-120(1)(a), (11)(c); 12-115-107(2)(a)(I); 12-155-106(2). Statute text read from the official Colorado Revised Statutes 2026 at leg.colorado.gov, August 2026. How to settle both questions for your parcel is worked in CO.4.

THE FOUR QUESTIONS THIS KIT MAKES YOU ANSWER FIRST

Nothing else can be answered until these are, and they are independent of each other — a jurisdiction can run an electrical program and not a plumbing one, because the statutes use different tests. Ask each separately and get the answers in writing. **(1)** Does my county or city require a building permit for a new single-family home, and under which code edition and amendments? **(2)** For ELECTRICAL, does my jurisdiction issue the permit and inspect, or do I buy a state permit? **(3)** For PLUMBING AND GAS PIPING, same question asked separately. **(4)** Where do my water and wastewater come from — and is a well permit obtainable here at all? In Colorado that last one is settled before design, not after (CO.2).

WHAT IS IN THE KIT

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
CO.1	The Owner-Builder's Legal Position	No state license, no state building code — and the two state trade permits that apply anyway. Includes the kit's headline trap: the homeowner electrical exemption is conditioned on getting inspected. Read this first.
CO.2	Permit Application Checklist	Two checklists — the local building permit and the state trade permits — plus the land approvals (water, wastewater, access) that gate everything in Colorado.
CO.3	Inspection Sequence	The local ladder, where the state electrical and plumbing inspections slot into it, and the utility release that is the real finish line.

The five documents

	Document	What it does for you
CO.4	Where to File Directory	How to determine who permits your parcel, the state agencies that own a piece, and a page to fill in your own offices.
CO.5	Forms & Documents Index	Each named form and permit you will meet, what it is, and which office it comes from.

HOW TO USE IT

Read CO.1 first, before you plan to do your own wiring or plumbing — Colorado's homeowner exemptions are real and generous, and the electrical one has a condition inside it that most people never see. **Work CO.2 with a pen**, starting with water and wastewater: a well permit is not a formality here, and in over-appropriated areas it can decide whether the house is buildable at all. **Keep CO.3 on the job** and log every inspection as it happens, including the state ones you schedule yourself and nobody will chase you about. And **fill in CO.4 before you need it** — Colorado splits the answers across a county, possibly a city, two state boards, a public health agency, and the Division of Water Resources.

How these facts were checked — and what this is not

Every Colorado claim here was read against its primary source in August 2026 — statute text from the official Colorado Revised Statutes 2026 published by the Office of Legislative Legal Services, board rules from the Code of Colorado Regulations, agency facts from the agency's own pages — and is cited where it appears. Colorado renumbered its entire professions title in 2019, so older guides cite sections that no longer exist; this kit uses current numbering. Where jurisdictions differ, the kit gives the verification step rather than an answer that would rot. This is a process reference, not legal advice.